Did Malta miss its recycling targets?

Testing the European Commission's July 2026 reasoned opinion against Eurostat recycling data

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

"Malta missed the targets for total packaging, paper and cardboard and metals."

European Commission, July infringements package, 8 July 2026.
Also: Malta failed to meet the 50% municipal recycling target "to be reached by 2020"; reasoned opinion INFR(2024)2135.

VERDICT: LARGELY SUPPORTED

Findings reproduce from Eurostat; one year of one target met

Version 1.0 · 13 October 2026
Status: no right of reply needed
Prepared from public sources and Eurostat data.
Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT
Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

In its July 2026 infringement package (8 July 2026), the European Commission wrote that **“Malta missed the targets for total packaging, paper and cardboard and metals”** in 2020 to 2023, and that Malta, with eleven other states, **“failed to meet the 50% target of preparing for reuse and recycling of municipal waste … which was to be reached by 2020”**. It decided to send Malta a reasoned opinion (INFR(2024)2135). We tested these findings against Eurostat’s published recycling rates.

1. **The infringement step is as stated.** The Commission’s page lists Malta (INFR(2024)2135) among the states getting a reasoned opinion, after letters of formal notice in July 2024. Malta has two months to respond; the Commission may then refer the case to the Court of Justice. A reasoned opinion is the Commission’s position, not a court finding.
2. **The municipal target was missed, by a wide margin.** Eurostat’s recycling rate for Malta was 10.9% in 2020 (target 50%), the lowest of the EU-27; it was 16.7% in 2024 against 48.1% for the EU-27.
3. **Total packaging and paper and cardboard were below target in every year, 2020 to 2023.** Total packaging: 40.0%, 36.8%, 30.8%, 43.4% (target 55%). Paper and cardboard: 47.8%, 45.3%, 40.6%, 53.6% (target 60%).
4. **Metals were below target in 2021, 2022 and 2023, but not in 2020.** Eurostat gives 57.2% for metal packaging in 2020 (target 50%), then 27.1%, 13.0% and 15.2%. The Commission’s wording covers the four years together.
5. **Verdict: largely supported (high confidence).** Each named finding reproduces from Eurostat. The caveats are the 2020 metals result and that we read the Commission’s summary page, not the decision text or the Directives.



10.9%
Malta’s municipal recycling rate in 2020 (target 50%); lowest in the EU-27

4 of 4
years 2020–2023 below target for total packaging and for paper and cardboard

3 of 4
years below the metals target (2021–2023); 2020 met at 57.2%

2 months
for Malta to respond to the reasoned opinion

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP
None: the findings are reproduced. A fully ‘Supported’ rating would need the decision text and the Directives’ calculation rules to be read and to match.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN
Evidence that the Commission’s compliance data for Malta differ materially from Eurostat’s, or that the case was closed or the opinion withdrawn.

IN THIS REPORT

1 The claim and what we could verify
2 Method
3 What the data show
4 Where the evidence points different ways
5 Testing the claim
6 Verdict and requests for evidence
7 Limitations

1 The claim and what we could verify

The wording is on the page "July infringements package: key decisions", published by the Commission's Representation in Malta for the decisions of 8 July 2026 [1]. We read it in full on 13 October 2026. Under the heading "The European Commission calls on 12 Member States to meet waste recycling targets" it says the Commission decided to "send a reasoned opinion to … Malta (INFR(2024)2135) … for failing to meet several waste recycling targets, based on the latest available data reported by Member States". It adds that the Commission "already issued letters of formal notice" in July 2024 and that the reasoned opinion "now has two months to respond", after which "the Commission may decide to refer the cases to the Court of Justice". Newsbook reported the decision on 9 July 2026 [2].

Source	What it says	Our access	Status
European Commission (Representation in Malta), July infringements package [1]	Malta, with eleven other states, "failed to meet the 50% target of preparing for reuse and recycling of municipal waste … which was to be reached by 2020". For packaging: "Malta missed the targets for total packaging, paper and cardboard and metals", within "several targets for 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023". The page lists material targets of 60% (glass), 60% (paper and cardboard), 50% (metals), 22.5% (plastics) and 15% (wood).	Full page read, 13 Oct 2026.	**The claim**
Newsbook, 9 Jul 2026 [2]	Reports the reasoned opinion in the outlet's own words.	Read, 13 Oct 2026.	Locator
Eurostat, cei_wm011 and env_waspac [3][4]	Recycling rate of municipal waste; recycling rates of packaging waste by material, by country and year.	Downloaded 13 Oct 2026 (data/cc-117/).	**Primary data**

We did not obtain the infringement decision text, the July 2024 letter of formal notice (neither is published on the page) or the Directives themselves. The target values below are those the Commission's page states; the total-packaging figure (55% minimum) is the lower bound of the "between 55% and 80%" on the same page. The Commission's original press-corner version of the package was not opened.

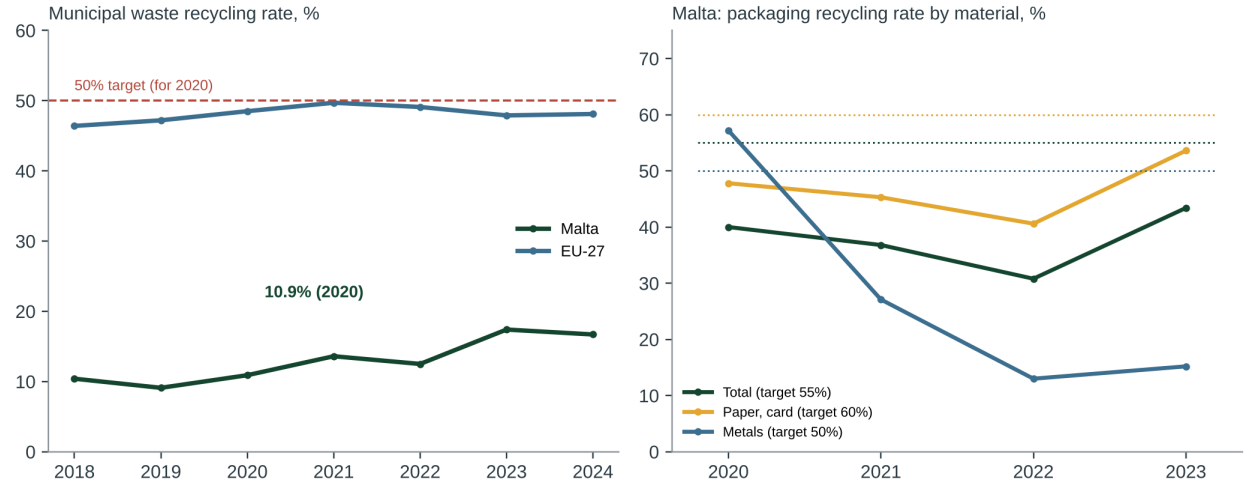
2 Method

Question. Do Eurostat's published recycling rates for Malta fall short of the targets the Commission names, in the years it names?

Evidence. We downloaded Eurostat's municipal waste recycling rate (cei_wm011, updated 30 March 2026) and packaging waste recycling rates by material (env_waspac, updated 11 May 2026) with *tools/cc-117-report/fetch.py*, and compared each rate with the target in *calc.py* (outputs in *data/cc-117/checks.csv*). Eurostat's rates are calculated by Eurostat from national reports; the Commission's compliance assessment uses the data reported by Member States under the Directives' own calculation rules. The two should agree closely but need not match exactly, so our check is an independent test of direction and size, not a reproduction of the Commission's calculation.

Grades. Official statistics are grade C in our scale. The claim is a regulatory finding; no peer-reviewed literature is needed to test whether published rates sit below published targets. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

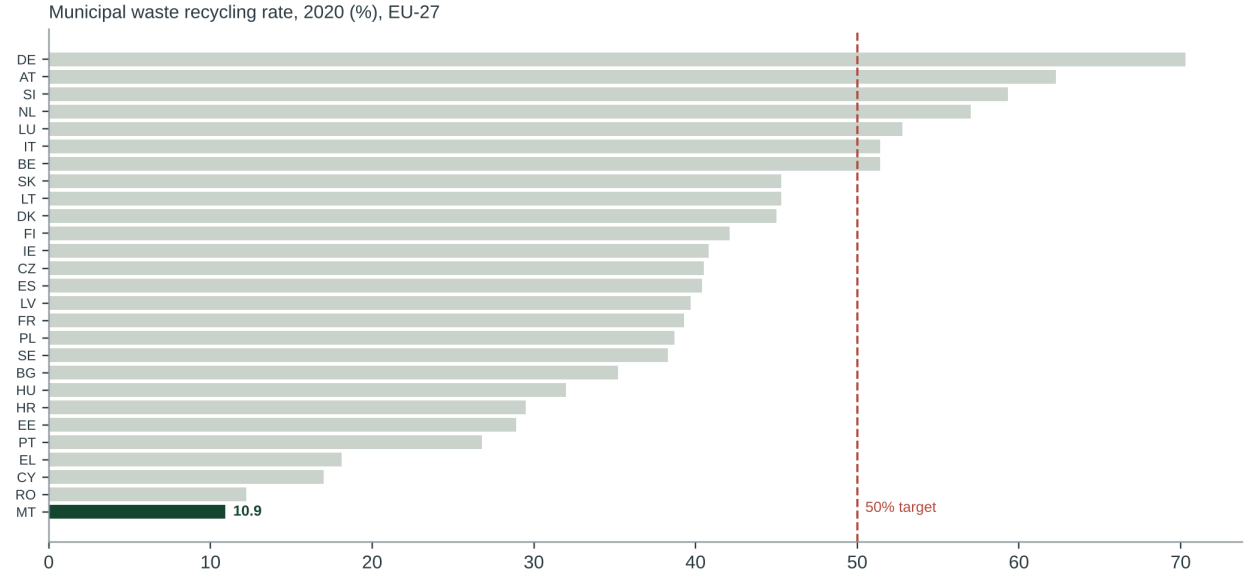
3 What the data show



Dotted lines: targets as listed on the Commission page (total 55%, paper and cardboard 60%, metals 50%). Source: Eurostat cei_wm011 and env_waspac, retrieved 13 Oct 2026.

Figure 1. Municipal recycling rate, Malta and the EU-27 (left), and Malta's packaging recycling rates for the three materials the Commission names, against their targets (right).

Malta's municipal recycling rate was 9.1% in 2019, 10.9% in 2020 and 16.7% in 2024; the EU-27 rate was 48.5% in 2020 and 48.1% in 2024. The 50% target applied to 2020, and Malta did not reach it in any year to 2024. For packaging, Malta's total rate was below 55% in all four years, with 43.4% in 2023; 3 of the 23 member states with 2023 data were below 55% (Romania 41.0%, Malta 43.4%, Greece 48.0%), and the EU-27 rate was 67.4%.



Eurostat cei_wm011 (recycling rate indicator), retrieved 13 Oct 2026. The Commission's list of 12 states rests on member-state compliance data, not on this indicator.

Figure 2. Municipal recycling rate in 2020, EU-27. Malta had the lowest rate on Eurostat's indicator.

4 Where the evidence points different ways

Were the metals target and the 2020 year both missed?

MOSTLY

FOR

The Commission says Malta missed the metals target within 2020–2023. Eurostat shows 27.1% (2021), 13.0% (2022) and 15.2% (2023) against 50%.

CAVEAT

Eurostat's 2020 value for metal packaging is 57.2%, above the 50% target. The Commission's sentence covers the four years together and does not say that every target was missed in every year.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

The statement holds for three of the four years. It would mislead only if read as every target in every year, which the Commission's wording does not claim.

Why does Eurostat show other shortfalls the Commission does not list?

UNEXPLAINED

THE COMMISSION

The Commission lists total packaging, paper and cardboard, and metals for Malta.

EUROSTAT

Eurostat's rates also fall below the page's targets for plastics (2020–2022), wood (0.0% in all four years) and glass (43.3% in 2022). We cannot say why the page does not list them: the Commission's assessment may use different reported data or counting rules (e.g. for wood), or a different reference year for the glass and plastics targets. We did not read the decision text.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

This does not contradict the claim, which names what the Commission found. It is a limit on how far Eurostat's indicator reproduces the Commission's list, and is not rated.

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. A reasoned opinion (INFR(2024)2135) was sent to Malta, the second stage, after July 2024 notices	EC [1]	Stated on the Commission's page and reported by Newsbook [2]. We did not see the decision text; no Maltese response found.	ACCURATE
B. Malta missed the 50% municipal preparing-for-reuse-and-recycling target for 2020	EC [1]	Eurostat: 10.9% in 2020, lowest of the EU-27; never above 17.4% to 2024.	ACCURATE
C. Malta missed the targets for total packaging, and paper and cardboard (2020–2023)	EC [1]	Total 40.0 / 36.8 / 30.8 / 43.4% against 55%; paper and cardboard 47.8 / 45.3 / 40.6 / 53.6% against 60%.	ACCURATE
D. Malta missed the metals target (2020–2023)	EC [1]	27.1 / 13.0 / 15.2% against 50% in 2021–2023; 57.2% in 2020 was above target.	ACCURATE, ONE YEAR MET

6 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

Each finding named in the claim reproduces from Eurostat, with one year of one target met. Confidence: high.

Why. The municipal target was missed by about 39 percentage points in 2020; packaging was below target for total and for paper and cardboard in all four years and for metals in three. The procedural statement is on the Commission's own page. We rate 'Largely supported', not 'Supported', because the metals target was met in 2020 on Eurostat's figures, and because we read the Commission's summary, not the decision text or the Directives.

What this verdict does not say. It does not rate how Malta's waste policy has performed since, or the Ministry's statements on separation (checked in CC-004). A reasoned opinion is a step in a procedure; it is not a finding by the Court of Justice.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ From the Commission: the decision text for INFR(2024)2135 and the July 2024 letter of formal notice, with the reported data and years behind each target.
- ☐ From the Government of Malta: its reply to the reasoned opinion, if published.

RIGHT OF REPLY

Not needed for this verdict (maintainer rule of 5 October 2026: a reply is sought only for *Not substantiated*, *Misleading* or *Contradicted*).

7 Limitations

- We read the Commission's summary page, not the infringement decision or the Directives; the targets are as that page states them. The 2020–2023 packaging targets are the 2008 targets; the higher targets apply from 2025.
- Eurostat's recycling rates are not the Commission's compliance calculation. Some Member States use alternative calculation methods under the Directives; we did not check which Malta used.
- Eurostat's 2024 EU-27 municipal rate carries the flag 'i' (see metadata). Packaging data end in 2023.
- The page was published by the Commission's Representation in Malta; its metadata give 8 July 2026 for the decisions. We did not find a Maltese response to the opinion.

References

[1] European Commission, Representation in Malta (8 July 2026). July infringements package: key decisions. https://malta.representation.ec.europa.eu/news/july-infringements-package-key-decisions-2026-07-08_en

[2] Balzan, J. (9 July 2026). EU escalates action against Malta over missed recycling targets. Newsbook. https://newsbook.com.mt/en/eu-escalates-action-against-malta-over-missed-recycling-targets/

[3] Eurostat. Recycling rate of municipal waste (cei_wm011), updated 30 Mar 2026, retrieved 13 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/cei_wm011/default/table

[4] Eurostat. Packaging waste by waste operations and waste flow (env_waspac), updated 11 May 2026, retrieved 13 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/env_waspac/default/table

[5] MiŻien. Calculation script and outputs: tools/cc-117-report/calc.py; data/cc-117/checks.csv. Related: CC-004, CC-111.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate**: evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low**: evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ◆ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline,** with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it,** and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify,** and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	13 Oct 2026	First issue. Verdict Largely supported (high confidence); no right of reply needed.